

The Tell: Which Pitch-Sequencing Giveaways Survive New Games, and Whether Hitters Cash In

Introduction. Advance scouts sell sequencing tells (“after a slider he doubles up”), and clubs act on them. No public method separates a real tell from one found by searching hundreds of pitchers, counts and previous pitches. We ask how much the previous pitch gives away beyond count and batter hand, how much of a scouted tell survives into new games, whether hitters punish it, and whether the 2026 automated ball-strike (ABS) system changed it.

Methods. All 2,049,352 regular-season Statcast pitches from 2024–2026 (1,793 pitcher-seasons with 250+ pitches). For each pitcher-season, nested models predict pitch type from batter hand, then count, then the previous pitch, scored on games they never saw. The gain from the previous pitch is TELL. A cue is the count, hand and previous pitch that most shifts one pitch type’s share. We find each pitcher’s top cue in April–June (or 2025) and score it only on later games. Whiff and run-value regressions on each pitch’s out-of-sample predictability hold pitcher-season, pitch type, count and velocity fixed. An in-season alarm multiplies game-by-game permutation e-values within count and batter hand. ABS is tested on paired pitchers against a 2024–25 placebo.

Results.

- Added in that order, batter hand and count carry 102 and 58 millibits about the next pitch; the previous pitch adds 8.1. Guessing the likeliest pitch, a hitter gains 0.6 points of accuracy, and 5 against Dylan Cease.
- Selection inflates tells. The top April–June cue shifts the next-pitch share by 26 points when found and 10 on July–September games, in the same direction 78% of the time (no tell: 0 points, 50%; Figure 1B).
- The ten largest 2025 cues all kept their direction in 2026, shrinking from 44 to 29 points (Table 1).
- TELL is stable within a season (odd-even reliability 0.73), not across seasons ($r = 0.19$; count usage 0.62).
- Predictable pitches are not punished. From the 10th to the 90th percentile of predictability, whiffs rise 0.6 points ($t = 4.7$) and pitchers save 0.23 more runs per 100 pitches ($t = 5.3$).
- The alarm fired for 25% of 2025 pitchers, at a median of 436 pitches, and for 1% of cue-free controls (Figure 1C).
- ABS lowered the top of the called zone by 1.2 inches (placebo 0.2) but moved TELL by -0.04 millibits (95% CI -1.47 to $+1.39$; placebo -0.25). The zone moved; sequencing did not.

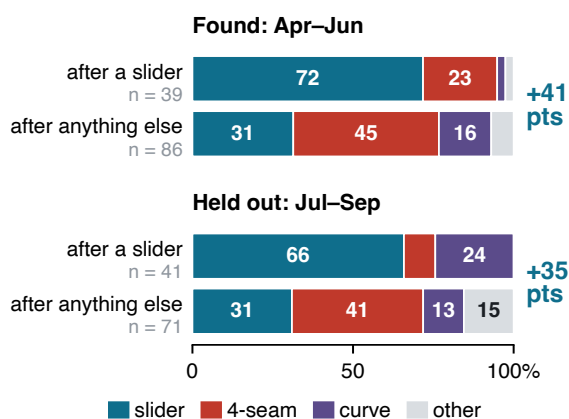
Conclusion. Sequencing tells are real but shrink by a third to two-thirds when held out, and a pitcher’s overall predictability is not a year-to-year trait. Scouts should discount tells accordingly. Hitters show no sign of exploiting them. The alarm flags cues in season with a controlled false-alarm rate. Code: github.com/aidaneichman/the-tell.

Table 1. Largest 2025 cues (50+ pitches; 25+ in 2026), held out on 2026. Next-pitch share shift after the cue (points).

Pitcher	Situation	Next pitch	Found 2025	Held out 2026	<i>n</i> 2026
Dylan Lee	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	slider	+66	+44	62
Jack Leiter	1-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	-46	-17	39
Kevin Gausman	0-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+45	+25	74
Chris Sale	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	4-seam	-44	-25	111
Gregory Soto	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+43	+22	48
Matthew Boyd	2-2 vs RHB, after change	4-seam	+41	+28	54
Hunter Brown	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+40	+36	50
Kris Bubic	1-0 vs RHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+38	+43	36
Drew Rasmussen	1-2 vs LHB, after cutter	cutter	-38	-26	51
Dustin May	1-2 vs LHB, after sweeper	sweeper	-37	-23	31

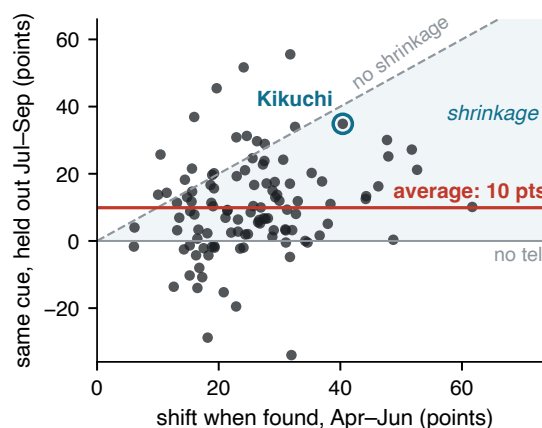
A One cue: Yusei Kikuchi, 2025, 1-0 count vs RHB

next-pitch mix after a slider vs after anything else



B Every pitcher's top cue, held out (n = 110)

found 26 pts, held out 10; same sign 78% (no tell: 0, 50%)



C An in-season alarm with a 5% false-alarm level

permutes pitch order within count and batter hand, game by game

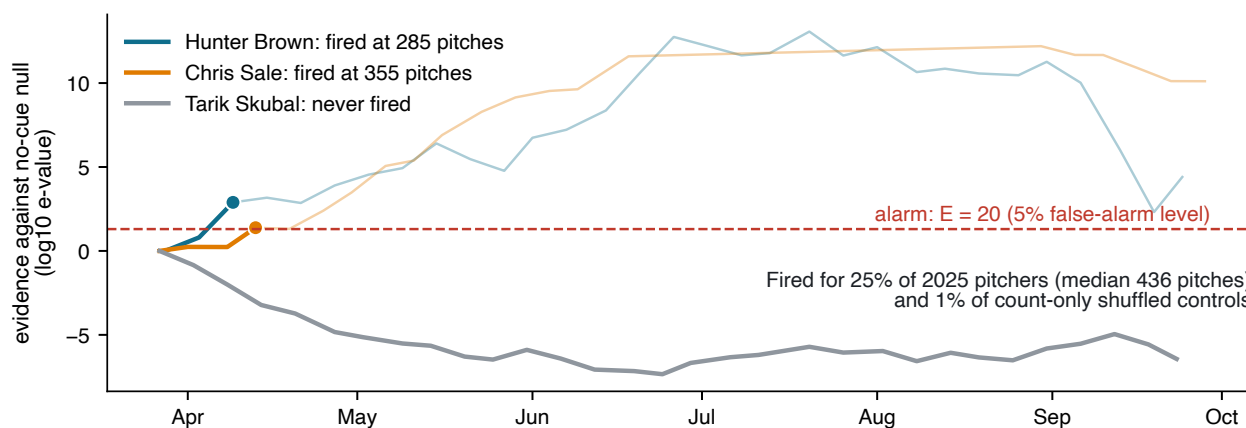


Figure 1. (B) Cues with 30+ pitches each way when found, 10+ held out.